



Prodigious talent: Anmol Kharb beat Thailand's Pornpicha Choeikeewong in the fifth and deciding match of the final to steer India to its first Badminton Asia Team Championships title. AFP

DESPITE BEING THE NATIONAL CHAMPION, ANMOL ADMITS SHE FELT NERVOUS WHEN SHE WAS INCLUDED IN THE INDIAN TEAM FOR THE ASIAN TEAM CHAMPIONSHIPS

the Asian Championships. Earlier, she defeated China's world number 149, Wu Luo Yu, 22-20, 14-21, 21-18 in the group stage and played a crucial role in India's semifinal win over Japan by beating world number 29 Natsuki Nidaira. Both of these victories were decisive in their respective ties.

Gopi Chand lavished praise on the youngest who, at world number 472, was the lowest-ranked member of the Indian team.

"To take the pressure on and show that kind of nerve, it is very

refreshing. She is fearless. The kind of strokes that she plays all come naturally to her. She is reading the game well; you can see her intelligence. She played beautifully," Gopi Chand would say.

As she flawlessly competed with older and higher-ranked rivals, it became clear that the 17-year-old was meant for the elite level.

However, it was by chance that Anmol stumbled upon badminton. Her father, Devender, played kabaddi for Delhi at the national level, but an injury forced him to

retire and pursue a career in law. Anmol's brother, Hardik, was a skater who also competed at the national level before a fall at high speed made him reconsider his interest in the sport.

"He was really good in studies, and after that fall, he didn't want to take a chance with injuries, so he gave that up. But I still wanted him to play some sport, so I decided to set up some cement courts in our housing society," says Devender.

While the court was meant for his son, it was Anmol, then just 10, who